

Canada

Professor says he lost job after criticizing Prozac

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A few months ago the renowned psychiatrist Dr. David Healy was ready to move to Toronto. He and his wife had already looked at houses in preparation for taking a job at the University of Toronto. But all that changed after he delivered a lecture critical of pharmaceutical giant Eli Lilly.

"The day after I gave the lecture here, as I understood it, and perhaps as early as the evening of the lecture, my job offer here had been effectively revoked," he said.

Eli Lilly is the company that makes Prozac, a drug prescribed to almost 40 million people worldwide for depression. But there's an ongoing debate suggesting Prozac may actually cause some people to become suicidal, even homicidal.

Those are dangers that Dr. Healy's been pointing out in lectures and essays, like the one he gave at the Centre for Addictions and Mental Health. The centre was his future employer and the recipient of \$1.5 million in funding from Eli Lilly.

Dr. Paul Garfinkel of the Centre for Addictions and Mental Health denies Healy's deal was revoked because of concerns about funding from the pharmaceutical company. But he won't say what the reasons were. "I explain it by saying there were so many factors that we came to feel this was not going to be the person for the job. And the factors are confidential."

The Association of University Teachers says that explanation is weak. "Is the University of Toronto saying we don't want to risk offending potential funders by having a scholar who asks certain questions?" asked the association's Jim Turk.

But officials at the Centre for Addictions and Mental Health say they've said all they intend to. They're already looking for someone else to fill the job Dr. Healy was supposed to start this month.

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